

STAGE TWELVE • LEADERSHIP

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Twelve • Leadership

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Twelve works best when participants have real leadership context to draw on, and a genuine facilitator challenge is supporting the participants who don't yet. Part 3 includes specific language for exactly this situation.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, anxious, or reluctant.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Twelve. This stage draws on nearly everything we've built so far — communication, teamwork, project management — and asks: what does it look like to actually lead, not just contribute?”

“If you've held a formal leadership title before, great, you have real material to draw on. If you haven't, that's completely fine too — everyone here has been led by someone, well or poorly, and that experience is just as valuable a starting point.”

Opening Session 2

“Last time was about setting the direction: goals, vision, delegation. Today is about the harder, more personal part of leadership — developing people, giving feedback, and handling conflict.”

“A few of today's exercises ask you to think of someone you currently lead, mentor, or coach in some way. If you don't have a formal example, an informal one, a younger sibling, a newer teammate, a tutee, works just as well.”

Opening Session 3 (Stage Close)

“Our final session moves into more complex territory: leading across functions, influencing without authority, staying steady under real pressure. We'll close today by writing your own leadership philosophy and a real development plan.”

“Keep in mind what we covered in Sessions 1 and 2 as we go — today pulls all of it together into something you'll actually carry forward.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST P3 → P4

"You've identified something you'll genuinely own. Leadership Role is the next step: actually stepping into a formal position where that ownership becomes visible and real."

FIRST P8 → P9

"You've just delegated based on genuine fit, not convenience. Now let's make sure whatever you delegated doesn't quietly slip through the cracks — that's what an accountability system is for."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Today was about direction — goals, vision, delegation, decisions. Next session gets more personal: developing the actual people on your team, one conversation at a time."

FIRST P14 → P15

"Mentoring is about building someone's capability over time. Coaching is more specific — helping them solve one problem right now, without giving them the answer. Let's practice the harder discipline of the two."

FIRST P16 → P17

"That was feedback on something fixable and low-stakes. Now let's talk about the conversations that are genuinely harder — the ones about a real, ongoing performance or behavior issue."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You've built real skill leading and developing the people directly around you. Session 3 zooms out — leading across functions, influencing people you don't manage, and staying steady when things get genuinely hard."

FIRST P24 → P25

"A crisis is one sharp moment. Pressure is often longer and quieter — let's talk about staying steady over weeks, not just minutes."

FIRST P28 → P29

"You've honestly named a real mistake and what you'd change. Let's turn that, and everything else from this stage, into something more lasting — the actual principles that will guide how you lead going forward."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

A participant has never held a formal leadership role and feels they have “nothing to say”

“You don't need a title to have real leadership material here. Think about a time you influenced a group outcome, organized something informally, or simply noticed what a good or bad leader around you actually did.”

Someone struggles to name a genuine current leadership decision for FIRST P10 or P11

“It doesn't have to be dramatic. A decision about how to divide a group project, whether to raise a concern, or how to handle a scheduling conflict all count as real leadership decisions.”

A participant gives feedback in the group version exercise (P16) that's clearly too soft to be useful

“Let's try that again, and this time, say the actual improvement area in one direct sentence before you soften it at all. We can add the context back in after.”

Someone is visibly nervous about the mediator fishbowl exercise (P18)

“This is a fictional, prepared scenario, not a real dispute — there's no wrong way to mediate it. The goal is just to notice what specific behaviors help or hurt, not to get it perfectly right.”

A participant resists writing a leadership philosophy (P29), saying it feels premature

“That's fair — this doesn't need to be permanent. Write what genuinely feels true based on what you've actually experienced so far. You can revise it in a year once you've led more.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, anxious, or reluctant — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST P11

Difficult Decision Made

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants may not have a genuinely difficult decision readily available, especially those with less leadership experience. Have a backup prompt ready: a difficult decision they observed someone else make, analyzed from the outside.

FIRST P17

Difficult Feedback Conversation

FACILITATOR NOTE

This can surface real anxiety, especially for participants who've been actively avoiding a specific conversation. Normalize the discomfort explicitly and keep the in-session work to preparation only — the actual conversation happens afterward, not live in the room.

FIRST P27

Leadership Feedback Received

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants may realize, in real time, that they've never actually asked for honest feedback and feel uncomfortable admitting that. Frame this as genuinely common, not a personal failing — most people haven't done this deliberately before this exercise.

FIRST P28

Leadership Mistake Reflection

FACILITATOR NOTE

This can bring up real embarrassment or shame about a genuine past mistake. Model vulnerability yourself if comfortable (briefly sharing a real leadership mistake of your own) to normalize honest reflection rather than deflection.